



David King,
Game Developer Consultant,
Discreet

// I'd like to
work at the
speed of
thought—you
think of
something
and do it



All in The Name of The Game

As a child, the England-born David King would often draw monsters in his art book, even as other youngsters would play soccer and cricket. His father, not exactly impressed with his choice of subject to show off his art, often admonished him.

Today, Daz, as the 27-year-old is known in gaming circles, makes more money in a year drawing monsters than his father spent on buying his first house. Of course, he never tires of pointing that out to him.

In his own words, Daz is a professional digital artist, consultant and 3DSMAX lecturer in Sydney, Australia. He is an artist of repute, not to mention a cinema freak and student, a quality he uses to the fullest while developing art assets for some of the world's top gaming titles.

Daz was in India recently, speaking on what goes into the making of a game. At the end of an offbeat, interactive lecture, Daz spent some time with Digit.

■ For many, developing games would seem similar to making an animated film. How close are they really to each other?

The processes are similar, but technically, there's a lot of difference. In gaming, scenes are rendered 60 times a second, while with movies, you can actually take days to do a render. So, it's a completely different scale. Solutions that work in games don't work in films, and vice versa.

■ nVidia's concept of "cinematic computing" is being talked about a lot? Are you excited about it?

Yeah, sure! I mean, real-time feedback makes an artist's life easy. What this means to the gamer is that, the next-generation games will be fast and fluid.

■ But cinematic computing's still a long way off, right?

Well, let me put it this way. Just about a year ago, if you'd told me about real-time bump-mapping in *DOOM III*, I'd have laughed at you. Advances in hardware are spiking; they're exponential. And so artists have to struggle to keep up with this. It's interesting to see the FX demos. They've just blown me away; they're incredible. But you won't see games go that way for a long time, simply because the cost of making assets that detailed and that complex is enormous. You've got to

paint high-resolution textures for all those characters, then the polygons, the subtlety and nuances in the face have to be just right. All this costs a fortune. (*What is cinematic computing? See box 'Cinematic Computing' on Pg 26*)

■ So how long do you think it'll take?

Don't think I can say. If I can draw a line from the time I started learning MAX until now, I'd say less than two years. I'd say they've got stuff running right now that's really impressive. Nothing very soon, but I don't think it'll take too long.

■ Why are monsters your favourite subject for your kind of art?

Monsters are great from an artistic standpoint; they're a manifestation of human fantasies and fears. A dragon is everything we fear—sharp teeth, fire, anger, rage, claws. H R Giger's *Alien* (Giger created the *Alien* in the eponymous Sigourney Weaver movie) carries great metaphors as well. With monsters, you're creating a human inside out, so there's great flexibility and interpretation.

■ Animated movies are growing in popularity. Will they ever replace conventional films?

Why would you want to do that? I think you'd miss the humanity in the acting performances. Anyway, I guess the one thing that stops virtual actors from becoming a reality is that you require more actors and more people to get a virtual actor to work. But technology is making creation of digital assets very simple. Sony ImageWorks, I think it was, was talking about a test they did where they had a young Harrison Ford's digital model acting beside the current Harrison Ford. It was like he meets himself as a young man. Apparently, it was just breathtakingly done. That would be an exciting reason to do it. But not replace real actors all together. The reason why Gollum (an animated character in *The Lord of the Rings* [LOTR] trilogy) looks so good is because the animation is done over a real actor, not like a virtual actor at all. Gollum is just like a digital rubber suit over an actor. But it's a really good one. So I think that's the way to go. We're already seeing that. I mean, Gollum's just so fabulous!

■ Which reminds me, what is your best work?

A lot of my best work never gets seen. I do a lot of pitch proposals for games. I was working on *Middle Earth Online* (a Massively Multiplayer Online Role-Playing Game [MMORPG] based on the LOTR